prime hitman thanks mainly to his ability to fluently speak Tamil, Telugu, Malayalam and Hindi. Contrary to reports, his Tamil was sans a Lankan accent. He was also familiar with the Indian topography, which stood him in good stead in eluding the super sleuths tailing him. One of his major advantages was the stark contrast between his side and front profiles. There was hardly any similarity between Haribabu's photograph of him, which showed him in profile, and the front view that appears on his driving licence.

According to Indian intelligence agencies, Sivarasan was assigned the task of killing the EPRLF leader K. Padmanabha. The slain leader was opposed to the LTTE's violent practices. Sivarasan, along with a deputy, Santhan, devised a plan and carried out Padmanabha's assassination in broad daylight in Madras in June 1990. Impressed by his work, the LTTE's intelligence chief, Pottu Amman, chose him for the task of killing Rajiv Gandhi.

## **MURUGAN (30):** Explosive expert

Murugan Sriharan was just twenty-one years old at the time of Rajiv Gandhi's assassination. A member of the LTTE's intelligence wing, he was trained in close-combat warfare and the making of bombs. He became an important member of the hit squad and was recognized for his expertise in explosives. He, too, was handpicked by Pottu Amman and sent to India to assist Sivarasan. The investigators called him 'a terrorist who turned Romeo'. He came to Madras to assist Sivarasan, provide logistics to the human bombs and hideouts where the assassins could be sheltered. While carrying out his task meticulously, Murugan fell in love with a local girl named Nalini, used her in his scheme of things and later married her. She became a key conspirator who facilitated the crime. He had reportedly surprised his own boss by procuring locally sourced RDX to be used later in the making of the bomb.

He also aided in a dry run carried out at the political rally of former Prime Minister V.P. Singh at Nandanam near Madras. The idea was to check